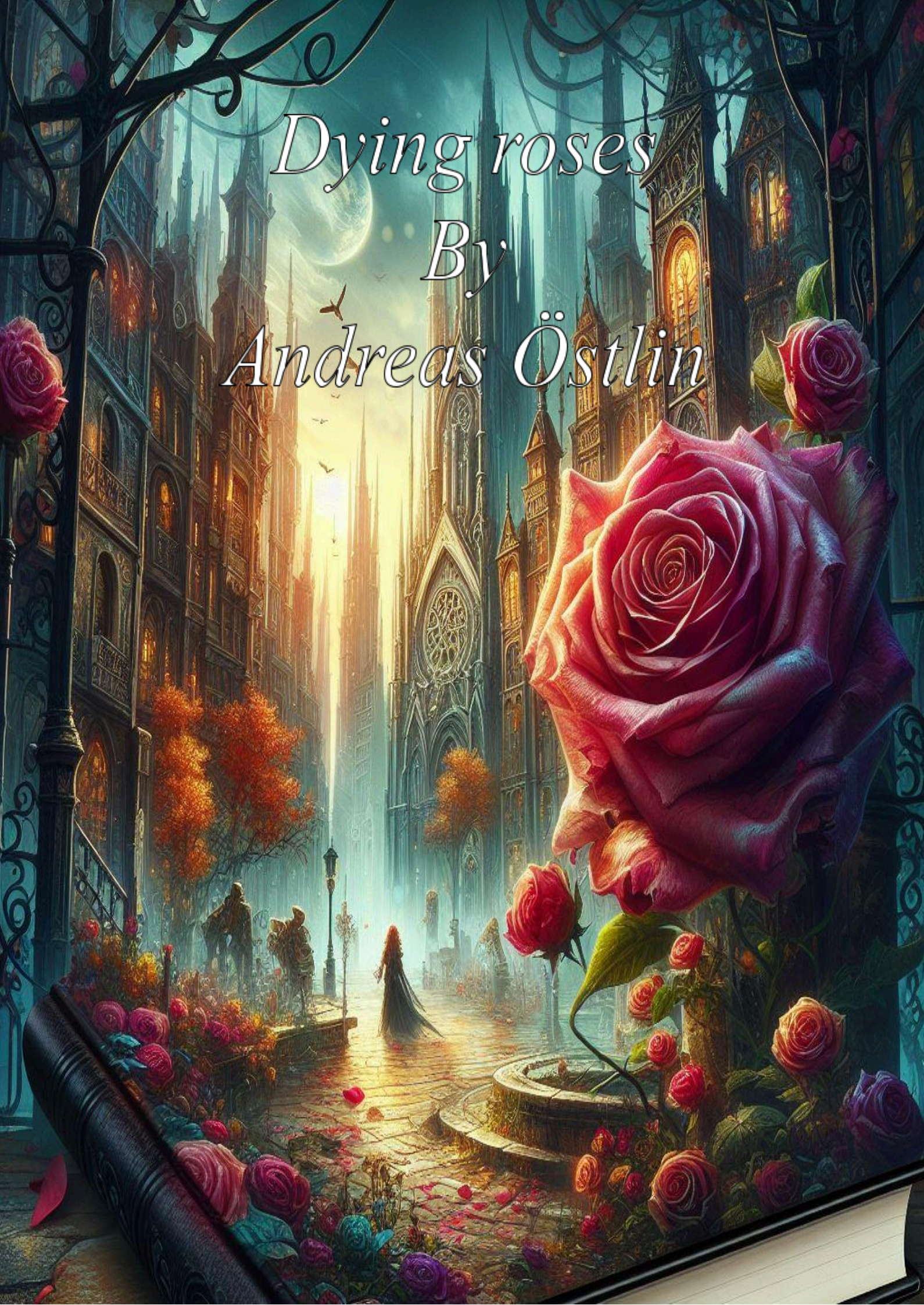
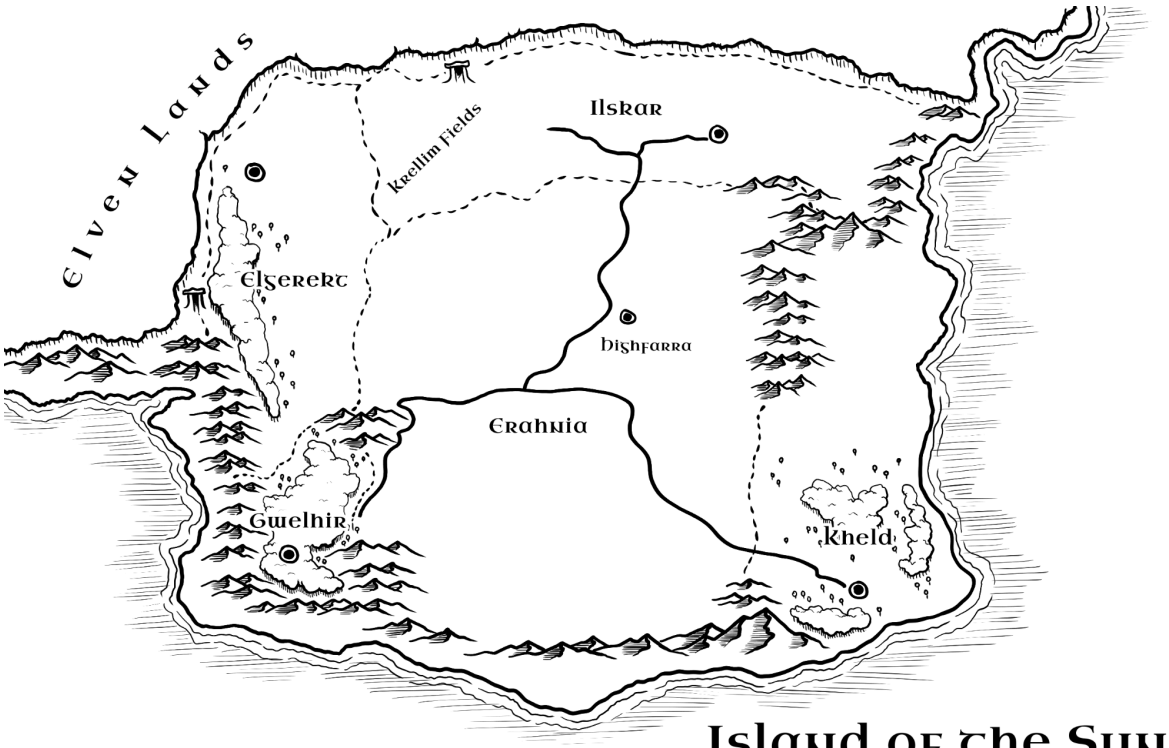


Dying roses

By

Andreas Östlin



Island of the Sun

Prologue:

Begrim slumped in his saddle after the long ride, making his way through a crowded camp. The atmosphere was thick; the smell of smoke, metal, and blood hanging in the air. Each man saluted or bowed as he passed. He could feel their determination but saw the weariness in their eyes and nodded back to each man in respect. The tents and supplies were so packed that he struggled to find passageways on horseback.

‘I'll have to lead the damned horse if it gets any more crowded. That would be a fine sight, wouldn't it, Begrim? Would have made your mother proud,’ he thought to himself with a grim expression as he slowly made his way forward towards the war tent on the eastern side of the camp. Finally dismounting, his boots sank into the mud. He patted his stallion's neck, offering a silent thank you for the earlier trials, before making his way toward his advisors tent.

The chatter of heated debate reached Begrim's ears well before he arrived at the tent. Despite his dislike for the inevitable bickering these meetings led to, he hurried towards the tent. The winds in Ilskar cut right to the bone, and he preferred to be out of the cold sooner rather than later. Flickering torchlight cast restless shadows onto the fabric walls, offering a silhouette of the animated conversation within. As he neared, a guard outside saluted, then flung the tent flap open, announcing, 'High King Begrim Whitmore of Erahnia!'

Inside were dignitaries from the four corners of his kingdom. The Lord marshal, an imposing figure from the barren north of Ilskar, stood tall and unyielding. Their

spiritual leader, from the land of Kheld, representing the clerics, wore garments of a unique teal hue. Her striking blue eyes were softly lit by torchlight in the meeting. Lastly, the slender scout from Gwelhir, was impossible to miss—a towering wood elf with sharply pointed ears and a cascade of orange hair that flowed down to his waist.

A hush fell upon the room.

Heads bowed, and a chorus of unified whispers greeted him: 'My king.' Acknowledging them with a raised hand, he skipped individual pleasantries; there were urgent matters to discuss.

Seating himself on a modest wooden throne at the far end of the tent, he got straight to the point. “Speak,” he declared. His tone brooked no debate. “I want the latest reports. Now.”

The Lord Marshal was the first to break the silence, his voice slicing through the thick tension like a blade. “My king, your sons have led the forces well, but the soldiers from Elgerekt did not receive their emissaries. Instead they have rampaged for over a week, killing and looting in their wake. They've made no attempts for diplomacy. Their purpose, it seems, is solely to destroy.”

The ranger stepped forward, “Our scouts have tried to approach their borders, but the Elgerekt have heavily fortified them. The paths we once used to meet with them have been closed off; many have died in the process. I believe it's too risky to travel into their lands now.”

Next, the cleric came into the light. Her face was troubled. “My liege, the magic they wield is like nothing we've seen. It decays the lands around them, it brings only death. Our healers are rendered helpless in the face of its darkness.”

Begrim listened, his expression growing grimmer with each report. At last, he stood, beginning to pace as he processed the news. "So you're telling me," he paused, inhaling sharply, "that after my mother orchestrated the largest military alliance in our continent's history. After enjoying nearly a century of unprecedented peace. We're now under attack from the Elgerekt? That these peaceful nomads have suddenly resorted to death magic?"

He paused, sinking back into his throne, his forehead resting in his palm.

His thoughts were in disarray ‘*And you promised I would be the first king to rule in peace, mother’* the thought nearly made him laugh in despair.

He carried on, "Lord Marshal," he stared down the towering figure, "Elgerekt has never involved itself in our conflicts or shown interest in our politics. Yet, I trust we have kept an eye on their military capabilities. For precaution, if nothing else."

The Marshal opened his mouth as if to protest, but stopped himself and then his gaze moved from the king to the ranger with a look of guilt.

The elf answered, nodding, "Indeed, my liege. The Lord Marshal instructed us to monitor their military power. A safety measure, undoubtedly." The elf shot an annoyed glance towards the Marshal.

Begrim shook his head slowly, mulling over the information. "Then, tell me," he continued, "do the Elgerekt, death magic or not, stand any chance against us in war?"

The Marshal, this time, answered firmly, having regained his composure. "Not a chance, my king. Our weaponry is superior, and our numbers are fivefold theirs."

Before Begrim could respond, a commotion erupted at the tent flap. Two guards, faces grim, burst through, hauling a wounded scout between them, his uniform dark with blood, his body limp yet tense with pain. The council fell silent, turning as one to the disturbance.

He could feel his heart sinking as he took in the scout's dire state. The soldiers laid their burden before the council, the scout's eyes found the king's. With a struggle that etched deeper lines of pain across his features, the scout delivered his message in a hoarse, barely audible whisper. 'They are here!'

Those chilling words sparked an immediate flurry of activity in the camp. Alarm bells clanged ominously. The leaders dashed to their respective stations, donning armour and rallying their forces.

The army assembled swiftly, forming ranks, archers, cavalry and footmen in neat formations before the enemy host could break through the edge of the forest on the opposing side of the field. From the forest's edge, the fearsome figures of Elgerekt berserkers emerged, their tall, bearded figures an imposing sight. They wore battered leather armour, in contrast to the Capital's polished chain mail and finely-woven uniforms. Each held dual battle axes or a single axe paired with a shield.

The king stood before his assembled troops, his eyes surveying the sea of faces in front of him, faces etched with a complex blend of fear, determination, and hope. He closed his eyes and steeled himself, he would need to rally these men if they were not to break before the battle, he drew his sword and held it high. "Soldiers of the Isle, today we stand at a precipice. It’s not just our survival that hangs in the balance, but the very essence of the peace our ancestors and we have laboured for years to uphold. Let them hear the thunder of our unity; let them feel the tremors of our resolve. For our homes, our kin, and everything we hold dear!"

As his words reverberated through the air, his men cheered, chants rose as those closest to the king relayed the words to those further away. Begrim's keen eyes noticed strange figures emerging from the Elgerekt lines. Hooded figures, their visages obscured, were directing the troops. They were surrounded by heavily armoured warriors, their armour darker and more ominous than anything he had seen before.

His mind was a whirlpool of questions. How had these once peaceful people been transformed into such a force of evil? He watched, his heart pounding, as he saw his two sons shouting orders from their mounts. They were tall in their saddles, and he was proud.

But there was no time to ponder any questions. Tightening his grip on the hilt of his sword, he took a deep breath and gave the order. His voice rose above the ambient sounds of a battlefield on the brink. "Charge!"

The ground shuddered under the blows of a thousand hooves. Steel sang against steel, drowning out cries in a symphony of violence. Horses, crazed and riderless, ran amok, painting the field with red streaks. Begrim tried to keep his bearing in the

chaos, his battle hardened horse grew agitated as the grass beneath its feat withered before one of the hooded figures. He fell from the saddle as his horse reared, he tasted dirt upon hitting the ground, the world was spinning.

He could see somebody approaching as he regained his vision. In black iron, a nightmare made of metal.

Begrim hauled himself up, his movements sluggish, he readied to defend himself. Blade crashed against blade, each clang a desperate prayer, each parry a defiance in the face of the inevitable. He felt his strength ebb with each blow.

Two weeks after the charge at Krellim Fields, which would turn out to be one of the kingdom's most devastating defeats. A kingdom was in mourning, and a young man knelt before an assembled court. He had lost both his brothers and his father, his face was etched with grief and the weight of responsibility. At the age of 24 he would be the youngest monarch in his country's history, a scholar thrust into a role he never desired, to lead a kingdom in times of war. He was the last wall standing against an enemy that wielded magic so malevolent it could raise the dead and corrupt the very soil upon which they fought.

As the young prince was crowned king, a different figure in a distant land delicately touched a dying rose in an expansive garden. "Come back to me, my love," he whispered, as though the words could breathe life back into the withering petals.

Chapter 1:

A Requiem for the Forgotten

A loud bang woke her. '*What is happening? Where am I?*' As her eyes adjusted to the light, the world revealed itself in a haze of agony and confusion. A battlefield, sprawling under an ashen sky, a field littered with the fallen, their banners unknown to her. She tried to recall her name, her purpose, but the more she tried, the more it eluded her.

In her mind, there was only one image: a hooded figure shrouded in shadow, raising a black blade. Then, unimaginable pain shot through her body, followed by nothingness.

She rose on shaky legs, surveying the shattered remnants of war. Dust and smoke turned the landscape into a ghostly scene, through which she could make out the remnants of loss. Trees, once towering and majestic, now stood mutilated. Here and there, fragile tufts of grass hinted at the vibrant life this wasteland once nurtured.

The field before her held splintered weapons and discarded armour. The thick smell of blood mixed with the earthy scent of rain-soaked mud. As her gaze sharpened, she saw figures before her: three warriors clad in crude leather armour, their hands gripping battle axes beside a fallen wolf-like creature. Were they friends or foes? She searched their faces for any sign of recognition, but all she found was shock, their features etched with fear as she regained her balance.

A battle cry pierced the air, catching her off guard. And before she could fully grasp the situation, the warriors charged. Her body responded instinctively.

She sidestepped an oncoming blade, grasped the assailant's arm, and used his momentum to hurl him to the ground. The world around her seemed to blur as she felt drawn to a gleaming blade nearby. She reached for it and plunged it deep into an approaching soldier.

Every parry, every dodge and counterattack, felt innate, as if she had performed this dance thousands of times before—a forgotten memory slowly resurfacing. And as the dust settled, a trail of fallen enemies lay in testament to her power.

"Look! They are fighting amongst themselves," a distant voice cried out, barely audible over the chaos of battle.

'More enemies?' she wondered, gripping the hilt of her blade tighter. But as she scanned for these newcomers, she noticed they were draped in neatly tailored tunics of teal cloth layered over chainmail—clearly a different faction, and by their defensive formation, an organised one. Her attention quickly shifted from their shouts as robed figures emerged behind the soldiers and began to encircle her.

They extracted small, carved stones from their pouches, the symbols on them faintly glowing. Poised to attack, she watched as they tossed the stones around her. The figures started chanting, their hands clasped as if in prayer, and the carvings on the stones began to emit a soft glow. Immobilised, she found herself unable to move; the more she struggled, the more difficult it became. Gritting her teeth, she hissed, "Release me…" Her eyelids grew heavy, and with a blink, she murmured, "You

demons…" What emerged was barely a whisper as she once again succumbed to the enveloping darkness.

She awoke, bound and battered, in what appeared to be a tent used as a temporary armoury. Despite her aching body, she tried to get her bearings, looking for anything that might aid her situation. In the corner of the tent, she noticed a set of black plate armour, distinct from both the leather worn by her attackers and the chainmail of her captors. *'Did I wear that?'* she wondered, squinting her eyes.

Through the commotion outside, she strained her ears, catching snippets of a conversation between the guards stationed outside. By the tone of their voices, she inferred they were confused.

"By Lumaire's light, We killed the Dark Master. Why is she still alive?" one guard murmured, a hint of fear in his voice.

"A bad omen, I'm sure,"

A second guard weighed in, "The Westfolk feared her as much as we did. And she was killing her own before we cornered her."

Their conversation ceased, replaced by a palpable tension. Someone was approaching. She collected herself, steadying herself for whatever came next. *'Why do I need to steady myself?'* she questioned internally. Her body seemed prepared to react, even if her mind did not know what to do.

The entrance to the tent was flung open, revealing an imposing silhouette against the backdrop of the setting sun. As her eyes adjusted to the light, she studied the man who entered. With tanned skin his youth seemed marred by battles, skin scarred and bruised, hand resting on his sword hilt. Black hair, like charcoal and neatly tied back, framed a pair of intense brown eyes. His armour, similar to that of his guards but adorned with gold embellishments, bore the crest of a mountain chain—a sign of high rank, she guessed. The large, calloused hands, especially the right one marked by a prominent scar across its back, testified to a man who did not shy away from battle. She thought she detected a tremble in his scarred hand. *'A scared boy at the front of an army?'* she wondered with a frown.

His gaze filled with awe or perhaps fear, as if he were confronted with a mythical beast brought to life. She felt a prickle of unease, a flicker of vulnerability. *'Am I a beast?'*

He broke the silence. "I am Ghalen Whitmore, commander of these forces." His voice carried an authority that belied his youthful appearance. "Reports suggest you've lost your memories," he remarked, his words echoing through the tent. A weighted pause lingered, expecting some form of acknowledgment, but she remained silent, lost in the maze of her thoughts. "You were fighting alongside the Western Elgerekt. Does that trigger any memories?"

'How does he know I lost my memories?' The commander's words faded into the background, as foreign to her as an unfamiliar tongue. She tried to make sense of it,

small fragments popped into her mind; they had questioned her earlier when they removed her armour. As he spoke of war, puppeteers of the dead, and her alleged role as a formidable general, she felt more lost than ever.

He continued to pace the room, muttering to himself or perhaps to her; it was unclear. "Perhaps a woodland elf?" he speculated, tracing the intricate markings on her face. However, his expression quickly shifted to one of doubt, and he shook his head in confusion, as if dismissing the possibility.

She turned to the side, catching her reflection in the polished shield by the wall. Her ears: long and pointed, almost twisting like ram horns. Skin pale and her hair, brown and silken. There was a flower-shaped jewel woven into her hair, it felt familiar somehow.

"Could you be...a high elf?" he asked, lowering his voice to a hushed whisper. It was as though it seemed he feared that if he spoke too loud it might dispel an illusion. "Are you from beyond the great Elven Wall?" Her heart fluttered at his words, an echo of familiarity ringing in her ears. The mention of the wall stirred something within her, like a half-remembered dream.

She had no answers. For the first time since waking up in the battle field, fear gripped her. She did not know her identity or nature. Yet, the men around her viewed her as a mythical creature. And she could feel inside, myths usually stirred fear and led to tragic ends. Her heart sank.

"No matter," Ghalen continued. "Our great warriors fell. The enemy raised them to fight for them. But when their masters died, so did the warriors. Not you. You still

stand, and even fought against them. I hope you can offer hope in this war. Regaining your memories might give us the knowledge to end it."

‘He wants me to end this war? I don’t even know who I am’. Ghalen's eyes locked onto hers, searching, questioning, she felt the weight of her lost memories pulling her into a void.

His stare was intense. "Do you truly not recall anything of your past?" he asked, a hint of desperation lurked behind that steady gaze.

She hesitated, feeling exposed. "I– I do not know who I am or where I came from," she admitted with a sigh. "Yet, the mention of the Elven Wall... It felt familiar, like a song I once knew."

His gaze softened for a moment. "Very well," he added. "Our path home to the capital will lead us past the great gate. Given recent events, I'm inclined to believe it might be beneficial for you to join us on this journey. However," he added, looking stern, "we cannot trust you. Restraints will be necessary."

Before she could respond, a guard stepped up, raising his voice. "Ghalen, Are you truly inviting this... demon to join us? The journey home is already dangerous without an enemy in our midst!"

Ghalen raised his hand. "Khain, my decisions are not made lightly. Do not doubt my judgement, banner general."

The man's voice wavered, "No, sire, but she fought against us. I fear for—"

“Enough” Ghalen interjected. "Fear has two sides: the known and the unknown. Maybe, by knowing her better, we might find an ally where once we saw an enemy. Besides, do you think one bound woman will defeat what remains of our company?"

Khain bowed his head. "Forgive me, I overstepped." He left with hurried steps.

Outside the tent, she could hear muffled voices, one whispering, "Has the boy lost his mind?"

Another voice shushed the first, "Be careful with your words! Do not question Ghalen's wisdom so boldly. He could have your tongue for that."

She thought her hearing might be sharp, because if Ghalen could hear the exchange, he showed no sign of it.

He turned back to her, extending his hand in a gesture of peace. "So, will you join us?"

She nodded slowly, *‘What else would I do?’*. "Yes, I will join you."

As she agreed, Ghalen gave a sigh of relief, though the weight of their agreement hung in the air. This was surely no simple choice—they were inviting a wild card

into their midst, *'Can I help end this war? Or will I make it worse?'* she thought, frowning at the ground.

The journey back to the east would be a test of endurance and patience, she was told. They were still within contested territory, with several days of arduous riding ahead. The enemy forces were scattered across these lands, and passage would not be easily granted.

The two guards stationed outside entered as Ghalen left, they hauled her to her feet and led her outside. Looking around the area she saw dirty, tired faces staring back at her. What remained of the victorious band seemed to be a force of less than a hundred strong. She could not tell what they were thinking as she was led past them, but she steeled herself, ready to face the challenges that lay ahead.

She found herself stowed in an open carriage, her wrists and ankles bound, and her body draped in a green cloak to shield her from the harsh winds. They had outfitted her in the teal robes of their healers, woven with brass detailing, very different from the menacing plate armour she had worn in battle. The looming darkness seemed to mimic her current state of mind—shrouded and uncertain. Around her, the men and women of the company prepared for travel, their movements efficient and sure, completely opposite to the turmoil within her.

She remained silent, her mind preoccupied with the haunting memory of the hooded figure and the searing pain that had consumed her. She closed her eyes, searching her body for any remnants of the wound. But there was nothing. No scar, no lingering ache. It was as if the memory existed in a realm separate from her physical being. A shiver ran down her spine, a disturbing realisation that she had defied death itself, emerging from the abyss untouched. Averting her mind from the dreadful

feeling, she once again thought about coming face to face with the Great Wall which brought a strange feeling of calm. Once more, her gaze settled on the distant battlefield where she had been captured. Despite the horror of the scene, she could not help but feel a bit sad. That field was the only thing she knew in this strange world.

Her captors' fallen comrades were retrieved and buried with ceremony, while the leather-clad berserkers became a feast for crows. There was much movement, packing and saddling of horses, carriages were being loaded, weapons cleaned and packed, soldiers administering first aid to each other, and those wounded beyond that were helped by cloaked figures she could only see in passing. She did not understand why, but for some reason carts were set off with just a couple of riders in different directions without any cargo, and many riderless horses in tow but before she could think to much about it, a large build soldier mounted the front of her cart grabbing the reins, he turned to face her, she was expecting a vicious glance, and a snarky comment but his face was kind and his smile was warm, "The name’s Pieor Orlek, I'm Ghalen's personal guard." he said while adjusting the reins. "Riding with him, I reckon we'll be crossing paths quite a bit, my lady." he turned back to face the other direction as Ghalen as he approached, he gave him a respectful nod.

Ghalen, mounting the carriage, declared, "Everything's ready. Our enemy should struggle to track us. Let's go."

They left the mangled battlefield behind. The war-tainted air gave way to the freshness of untouched nature, a balm to her soul. Gradually, she began to surrender to the lulling motion of the cart, dozing off to the rhythmic movement of the horses'

hooves against the earth. The carriage continued its steady journey, and her mind wavered in visions of war, destruction, and always the hooded figure looming over her.

She slowly came to, the sun was no longer in the sky. Hearing the hushed voices of the two men at the head attempting to whisper over the rumble of the carriage. Pieor, driving the cart, barely maintaining his composure, was engaged in a speculative conversation with Ghalen.

"Could she really be a high elf like the stories?" Pieor's voice quivered with doubt. "I thought they all left thousands of years ago. Maybe she is just a strange looking Gwelhir elf?"

"Why don't you ask her, Sir Pieor?" Ghalen countered. Throwing a glance backwards.

Turning around with an embarrassed blush on his cheeks, Pieor quickly apologised.

"I'm afraid I can't recall anything from my past…sir," she confessed, trying to finish with the proper courtesy. "Can you tell me about these Gwelhir elves? Do they look like me?"

By the reflections in a shield during her interrogation, she had deduced her appearance was very different from that of the humans who captured her.

Pieor was scratching his chin, trying to recall something, "Well, the elves of Gwelhir live much longer than us, that's for sure. And their ears are much longer too."

He eagerly commenced his explanation. "My old nan always said, the longer the ears, the longer they live.

"Nonsense," Ghalen interrupted. "Elves' ears have nothing to do with their lifespan. It's said the woodland elves are descendants of the high elves, who intermingled with ancient humans. And over time, they strayed from their ancestral customs and gradually lost all resemblance to their elven kin. Where the high elves were said to live forever, their woodland relatives would live for a few hundred years."

Pieor quickly resumed, unaffected by his commander's corrections. "That may be, but your ears," he remarked, pointing at her, "your ears are even longer than theirs. And the markings on your face – elves are born with them, you see. But woodland elves sport green markings, yours are as blue as the summer sky!"

“And would my looks make me more similar to these high elves you speak of?” she asked.

Pieor looked at her with his mouth open, not quite sure how to respond.

He appeared relieved when Ghalen instead answered, “We could not say, the gates to the supposed high elves have been closed for thousands of years, and the elves of those lands are nothing but legends to us. Our priests worship remnants of what they left behind.”

She sat in silence for a long while, just listening to them talk, pondering what was said, she had no memory of any elves, or anything but her seeming death for that matter, but she did not trust these men enough to share that memory.

As the carriage trundled forward, the wind was a constant companion. She saw the land transform from bleak wasteland touched by war to more welcoming terrain. It was not the lush utopia; but a harsh landscape with trees sparse and leafless, even

though whispers spoke of it being springtime. Abandoned farms and desolate fields told stories of more prosperous times gone by.

Soldiers of varying ranks and attire frequently passed them, each offering a respectful nod to Ghalen. Pieor, who controlled the reins of her carriage, was the only one not giving her suspicious stares; he would even engage in conversation. Their exchanges provided a welcome distraction, keeping the shadows of her troubled thoughts at bay. Her captors did not seem all that bad, this Pieor seemed quite kind to her.

When the sun reached high in the sky, casting a warm light that hinted at the summer to come, four distinct riders appeared. The teal of their hoods resembled the one she wore, adorned with intricate bronze jewellery, the riders felt familiar. Could they be the same figures who had ensnared her with their magic on the battlefield? Their hoods were pulled back now, revealing their faces. She thought them beautiful, ice-blue eyes set against bronze skin, framed by raven-black hair dripping with jewels. Their regal bearing was evident, even in their saddles.

They offered the customary nod to Ghalen, but they seemed to look right through Pieor sitting next to him at the helm. The elf thought she could sense an undercurrent of tension. The other soldiers' glances were suspicious; indeed, some seemed to even move out of their way as if avoiding a bad smell when passing the riders.

Too curious to keep quiet, she turned to Pieor, "Who are they? And why do they seem so...unwelcome among the soldiers?"

Pieor sighed deeply, scratching his moustache. "Them? They're the Kheld, from the far south. Priests and priestesses of the Church of Lumaire in the capital. They're usually engrossed in their books and they know some healing arts. In most places across the Isle, they’re revered," he muttered, clearly annoyed.

She couldn't catch everything he said, but she thought she heard something like, 'They should be grateful the head of the tower herself rides with us.' He continued, "But this is Ilskar. Books don't fend off wolves or bring in the harvest. I've learned a few things since moving to the capital, in no small part thanks to Ghalen, but people here are sceptical of what they don't understand. Funny how quickly that changes when they’re injured," he added, a note of amusement flavouring his voice.

This Sir Pieor appeared to be a talkative man, something she did not mind very much as she was curious about most things and he seemed indulged to teach her. He had been talking for the good part of a day before the sun was setting and the cold began kicking in. A scout had returned some minutes earlier with suggestions for a campsite, an enclave some fifteen minutes ride away. She tried to huddle herself in her cloak the best she could to fight the cold *‘A fire would be nice’* she thought as they approached the future camp.